



THE HILLS HAVE AGAIN ERUPTED IN FURY. On August 5, torrential rain over the high-altitude Uttarkashi district in Uttarakhand triggered landslides and flash floods, swelling the Kheer Ganga, which then hurtled down its course, freighted with a mass of debris made of boulders, vegetation and mud loosened from surrounding mountains. This cascading, frothing wall of sludge slammed into Dharali village around 1.50 pm, engulfing houses, hotels and vehicles, smothering many souls. Further downstream, Harsil, then Sukki, stood in its destructive path. Over 100 people were missing at last count, including 10 Indian army soldiers from their camp in Harsil. However, scores were saved by rescue operations mounted by personnel of the army, the state disaster response force, the administration and the police. Still, urgently required relief work is impeded by destroyed roads. Indian Air Force helicopters have been pressed into service. Search teams have been dispatched with rescue equipment; populations in downhill towns Bhatwari, Maneri, Gangori and Uttarkashi alerted. The next few days will be crucial. The tragedy is the latest in a series of calamities in the Garhwal Himalayas. In June 2013, thousands of people were lost to floods and landslides following a cloudburst in the upper reaches of the Mandakini. In the Chamoli Disaster of February 2021, an avalanche in the headwaters of the Rishiganga triggered landslides, killing some 200 people. The frequency of these incidents has triggered concerns about 'anthropogenic factors' such as climate change, unregulated development of towns, hydel infrastructure and haphazard road construction as a catalyst for 'natural' disasters.

100+

NUMBER OF PEOPLE, INCLUDING 10 ARMY PERSONNEL, MISSING IN UTTARKASHI FLASH FLOODS; FIVE DEAD

190

NUMBER OF PEOPLE RESCUED FROM DHARALI VILLAGE

